Notes for Prof. Akihiro Inokuchi

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Thank you for agreeing to write for me. This memo collects facts—periods, what I worked on, and episodes with dates—to help you recall our work. It is not a draft letter; what to evaluate and how is entirely yours. Details: ozatamago.github.io/research; CV: ozatamago.github.io/assets/cv.pdf.

Our working relationship

- We have worked together since fall 2023—through your courses, research supervision, and my exchange preparation. Member of your lab since Aug 2024; you supervise my undergraduate thesis.
- Your courses I took (all spring 2024, third year): Data Mining (S); Exercise in Data Mining (A+); Advanced Seminar on Computer Science A (S). S is the top grade (90–100), A+ the next (85–89).
- How we interacted: until my exchange year, a weekly one-on-one progress meeting, and a talk of about 30 minutes at the lab-wide study group about every three weeks. During and since the exchange year (from Aug 2025) we have been in touch less often.

Academic record

- B.Eng. in Computer Science, School of Engineering, expected Mar 2027; GPA 3.62/4.00. Ranked 3rd in the program (90 places, 104 students in my year) by the program's ranking, which also counts credits earned (as of Mar 2026).
- Exchange student at the University at Albany, SUNY, Aug 2025 – May 2026; 8 courses, GPA 4.00/4.00: Continuous Probability and Mathematical Statistics; Bayesian Data Analysis; Ordinary Differential Equations; Capstone Project in Computer Science; Applied Stochastic Processes; Introduction to Differential Geometry; Machine Learning; Robotics.

Research in your lab

Graph neural networks that learn sparse structure (May 2024 – Apr 2025)

- Designed a graph neural network (MEG) that keeps only the edges of a graph needed for the task, using reinforcement learning to decide which edges to keep, so that fewer edges are used. Code: github.com/ozatamago/MEG.
- Given vs. mine: the broad direction (graph neural networks) came from the lab; the idea of choosing edges with reinforcement learning, and the design, implementation, and evaluation, were mine.
- Results: the model did use fewer edges, but I could not get the reinforcement learning to train well, and its accuracy stayed below that of a standard GCN.

Undergraduate thesis (due Feb 2027)

- Theoretical analysis of algorithms that maximize an unknown function with few trials (Lipschitz bandits), building on my research with Prof. Chong Liu (paper under review).
- Progress so far: presented at the thesis mid-term presentation (around Sep 2026). Before it, you corrected my one-page A4 summary and my slides.

Episodes you may remember

1. **Fall 2023 (second year) — asking about graph neural networks.** After Computer Programming III, I asked you about learning graph neural networks, because I wanted to do machine-learning research related to biology. I then read papers and textbooks and implemented graph neural networks myself, which led to MEG from May 2024.
2. **May 2024 – Apr 2025 — weekly reports on MEG.** After discussing ideas for improving the model with you, I tested them in small experiments, reported the results each week, and chose the next step from what I found.
3. **2024–2025 — exchange preparation.** You wrote a letter for my study-abroad scholarship. You also advised me, when going abroad and choosing a professor to work with there, to choose a pioneer in a field that few others have entered yet. During the exchange I kept you updated on my research outside the lab (Albany, RIKEN, IBM).

4. **Sharing with other students.** Advised younger students on study abroad and graduate school, and gave a lunchtime talk and Q&A session on my exchange year (Jul 6, 2026). Introduced a classmate interested in a lab at the University of Osaka to that lab; the classmate later joined it.

How the three letters fit together

Schools read the three letters side by side, so it helps if each covers what that recommender saw most closely. My suggestion, which you are free to ignore:

- **Prof. Takahashi:** the main research (OFML, ProtocolUCB) and the lab automation—taking a research question to a method, theory, implementation, and experiments on physical instruments.
- **Prof. Inokuchi:** computer-science foundations and growth through undergraduate research (sparse graph neural networks, the undergraduate thesis).
- **Prof. Liu:** mathematical research (problem formulation, proofs, re-examining lower bounds) and research carried out in English.

Please describe only what you observed directly. My work with IBM (SPIN) and at the University of Osaka is in the CV as background; I am not asking anyone to evaluate it.

If you adjust by program (optional)

Your letter is the main view of my academic preparation in computer science and of how I grew through undergraduate research. For Stanford CS, that foundation and the design of models for structured data. The other programs are in bioengineering, chemical engineering, or the life sciences (BU CompE, Columbia BME, UCSB BioE, Berkeley CBE, UC Riverside CEE, NYU BME, Northwestern IBiS, Cornell Food Science); for these, learning a new field on my own initiative and handling graph-structured models. The facts stay the same either way.